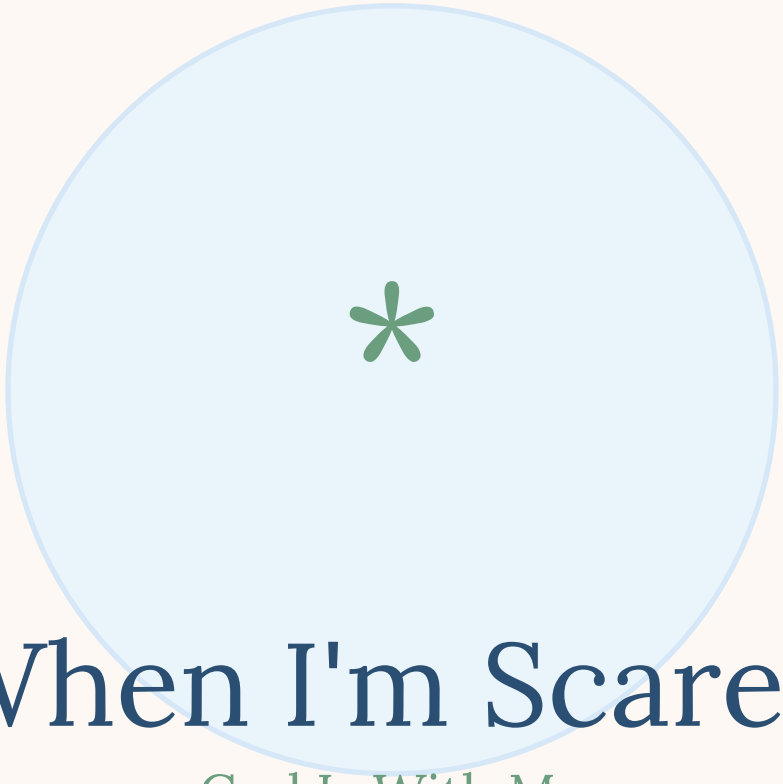
A guided journal for kids about anxiety, your body & God's peace



When I'm Scared

God Is With Me

"Do not be anxious about anything..."

— Philippians 4:6

This journal belongs to:

_____

For every child who has felt their heart race — you are not alone, and you are deeply loved.

A NOTE FOR GROWN-UPS

This journal was created for children (approximately ages 8–14) who experience anxiety, worry, fear, or times of feeling overwhelmed. It is not a replacement for professional mental health care — if your child is struggling significantly, please speak with your pediatrician or a licensed counselor.

What this journal does

It uses simple, honest science to help children understand why their body reacts the way it does during anxiety — because knowing what is happening makes it less scary. Then it anchors that science in the truth of God's Word, showing that what science describes as "calming the nervous system," the Bible calls the "peace of God that surpasses understanding." Both are real, both matter, and God designed both.

How to use it

There is no right order. Let your child start where they are drawn. Each section stands alone. Some pages are for reading together. Some are private writing pages — honor that privacy. The prayer breathing exercises can be practiced daily, not just in crisis moments.

A word to your child: You are so brave for picking up this journal. Whatever you are feeling right now — scared, worried, overwhelmed, tired, or just a little uneasy — this book is for you. Your feelings are real. Your body is real. And God is real. Let's explore all three together.

With love,

The team who made this for you

What's Inside

Part 1	Your Amazing Alarm System	*How anxiety works in your body*
Part 2	Your Feelings Have Names	*Understanding what you feel*
Part 3	What God Says About Fear & Worry	*Scripture for every storm*
Part 4	When It Gets Really Dark	*Depression, pain, and God's comfort*
Part 5	The Prayer That Calms Your Body	*How prayer and breathing bring peace*
Part 6	My Daily Check-In Pages	*Your personal journaling space*
Part 7	My Prayer Journal	*Talking to God in writing*
Part 8	My Brave Moments	*Celebrating progress*

PART 1 — YOUR AMAZING ALARM SYSTEM

Your Body Has an Alarm System

Have you ever felt your heart pounding really fast before a test? Or gotten a stomachache before something scary? Or felt like you wanted to run away or couldn't move at all? That is not you being weak. That is your body doing something incredibly smart.

Meet Your Amygdala (ah-MIG-dah-lah)

Deep inside your brain is a tiny, almond-shaped part called the amygdala. Think of it as your brain's alarm bell. The moment it senses something could be dangerous — even if it isn't actually dangerous — it rings the alarm. LOUD. And your whole body responds.

Scientists who study brains (called neuroscientists) have found that the amygdala sends out an emergency signal before the thinking part of your brain even has time to figure out what is happening. That is why anxiety can feel like it comes out of nowhere — because it does!



What your body does when the alarm goes off

When the alarm rings, your brain releases chemicals — especially one called cortisol (the "stress hormone") and adrenaline. These flood your body and cause all of those feelings above. Scientists call this the Fight, Flight, or Freeze response.

FIGHT	FLIGHT	FREEZE
You feel angry, frustrated, want to argue or push back	You want to run away, hide, or avoid the scary thing	Your mind goes blank, you can't speak, you feel stuck

Here is the important thing to know

This alarm system is a gift from God. He designed it to keep you safe. Without it, you could not react quickly if you truly were in danger. The problem is that our alarm systems sometimes go off when there is no real danger — like before a test, a new school, or when we feel lonely. That is when anxiety feels like too much. But your body is not broken. It is just trying to protect you.

PART 1 CONTINUED — YOUR BODY'S RESPONSE

What Happens When the Alarm Stays On Too Long

God designed anxiety to be short — sound the alarm, deal with the danger, calm back down. But sometimes the alarm stays on. This is what doctors call chronic anxiety. When stress hormones like cortisol stay in your body for too long, they can cause:

Trouble sleeping	Your body stays "on alert" even at night
Stomach problems	Your digestion slows down when in "alarm mode"
Trouble focusing	Your brain is busy scanning for danger, not learning
Feeling tired all the time	Running on alarm mode uses a lot of energy
Feeling irritable or sad	Long-term stress hormones affect your mood

None of these things mean you are weak or broken. They mean your body is working hard. And God — who designed your body — understands every single one of them.

> *"For you created my inmost being; you knit me together in my mother's womb. I praise you because I am fearfully and wonderfully made."*
>
> — Psalm 139:13–14

God made your brain. God made your amygdala. God made the cortisol. He knows how every part of you works — and He is not surprised by your anxiety. He meets you right in the middle of it.

Write It Out

Where do you feel anxiety in your body? Circle it on the body diagram above, then describe it here:

What does it feel like in your body when you get scared or anxious?

Can you remember the last time this happened? What set off your alarm?

PART 2 — YOUR FEELINGS HAVE NAMES

Understanding What You Feel

Scientists and counselors have discovered something important: when you can name a feeling, it actually becomes less powerful over your body. Naming your emotion activates the "thinking" part of your brain and starts to calm the alarm bell. This is called "name it to tame it."

Anxiety

A worried feeling that something bad might happen. Your heart races, palms sweat, stomach flips. The danger may not even be real — but your body acts like it is.

Worry

Thinking over and over about something that might go wrong. Like a song stuck in your head that you didn't choose.

Fear

A response to something that feels truly dangerous, right now. Your body is designed for fear — it helps you respond fast to real threats.

Stress

The feeling of having too much to handle at once. School, friends, family, changes — it can pile up until your body says 'enough!'

Sadness / Depression

Sometimes anxiety leads to feeling heavy, hopeless, or flat. Depression is when sadness doesn't lift for a long time. This is real and it needs real help — from people who love you AND from God.

Overwhelm

When everything feels like too much all at once. You might shut down, cry, or feel frozen. This is your system saying it needs rest.

Which one feels most like you right now?

Describe what you are feeling today in your own words:

It is okay if you feel more than one of these at the same time. Our hearts and bodies are complex — and God holds all of that complexity in His hands.

> *"Cast all your anxiety on him because he cares for you."*
>
> — 1 Peter 5:7

Notice what this verse says: all your anxiety. Not some. Not the "acceptable" kind. All of it. God's invitation is total.

PART 3 — WHAT GOD SAYS ABOUT FEAR & WORRY

God's Words for Every Storm

The Bible mentions "do not fear" and similar commands over 365 times — once for every day of the year. This does not mean God is dismissing how hard it is to feel afraid. It means He is constantly reminding us that He is present. Every verse below is a hand reaching toward you.

"Do not be anxious about anything, but in every situation, by prayer and petition, with thanksgiving, present your requests to God. And the peace of God, which transcends all understanding, will guard your hearts and your minds in Christ Jesus."

— Philippians 4:6–7

"When I am afraid, I put my trust in you."

— Psalm 56:3

"Have I not commanded you? Be strong and courageous. Do not be afraid; do not be discouraged, for the Lord your God will be with you wherever you go."

— Joshua 1:9

"He gives strength to the weary and increases the power of the weak."

— Isaiah 40:29

"For God has not given us a spirit of fear, but of power and of love and of a sound mind."

— 2 Timothy 1:7 (NKJV)

"The Lord your God is with you, the Mighty Warrior who saves. He will take great delight in you; in his love he will no longer rebuke you, but will rejoice over you with singing."

— Zephaniah 3:17

"Come to me, all you who are weary and burdened, and I will give you rest."

— Matthew 11:28

"When anxiety was great within me, your consolation brought me joy."

— Psalm 94:19

PART 3 CONTINUED — LIVING WITH THE VERSES

A Closer Look at Philippians 4:6–7

This may be the most powerful anxiety verse in the entire Bible. Let's break it down word by word:

"Do not be anxious about ANYTHING"

Not some things. Not small things. Everything — tests, friendships, family, the future, your body. God says bring it all.

"...but in EVERY situation..."

Paul wrote this from prison. From actual chains. He knew real suffering — not pretend hardship. This verse applies to your real hard things too.

"...by prayer and petition, WITH THANKSGIVING..."

Notice the "with thanksgiving." This doesn't mean pretend everything is fine. It means choosing to remember what God has already done while asking for help now.

"...the peace of God, which TRANSCENDS ALL UNDERSTANDING..."

Even scientists cannot fully explain why praising God lowers anxiety. But research shows it does. God's peace is bigger than logic.

"...will GUARD your hearts and minds in Christ Jesus."

Guard — like a soldier protecting a gate. Jesus stands between your heart and the flood of fear. He is your shield.

My Favorite Verse

Which scripture above means the most to you? Write it here and explain why:

My verse:

Why it means something to me:

PART 4 — WHEN IT GETS REALLY DARK

Depression, Pain & God's Presence in the Dark

Sometimes anxiety doesn't just feel like worry. Sometimes it feels like a heavy, dark blanket you cannot get out from under. Sometimes you feel hopeless, or like you don't matter, or like the sadness will never end. That is called depression, and it is very real.

What is depression?

Depression is not just "being sad." It is when sadness, emptiness, or hopelessness stays for weeks and doesn't lift. It affects how you sleep, eat, think, and feel about yourself. It is not a character flaw. It is not weakness. It is something that happens in the brain — in those very same pathways that God designed — and it can be helped.

Important: If you feel this way, please tell a grown-up you trust — a parent, a teacher, a pastor. You were never meant to carry this alone. Jesus himself said, "Come to me, all who are weary." Getting help is not giving up on God. It is saying yes to the people and tools He put here for you.

People in the Bible Who Struggled

You are in extraordinary company. Look at what some of God's most beloved people experienced:

Elijah

This mighty prophet defeated hundreds of false prophets — then ran into the desert and asked God to take his life. He was exhausted and done. God's response? He gave him food, water, rest, and a gentle voice. (1 Kings 19:1–18)

King David

He wrote Psalm 22: "My God, my God, why have you forsaken me?" He felt completely abandoned. Yet he kept crying out to God — and God heard him. The Psalms are a book full of depression, anxiety, and eventually, praise. (Psalm 22, 42, 88)

Jeremiah

Called the "Weeping Prophet," he was so overwhelmed he cursed the day he was born. God did not rebuke him. God stayed with him — for decades of painful ministry. (Jeremiah 20:14–18)

Jesus Himself

In Gethsemane, Jesus said "My soul is overwhelmed with sorrow to the point of death." He sweat drops of blood. He asked God to take the cup away. He knows suffering from the inside. He is not a stranger to your dark night. (Matthew 26:38)

> *"Even though I walk through the darkest valley, I will fear no evil, for you are with me; your rod and your staff, they comfort me."*
>
> — Psalm 23:4

Through — not around. Not over. Through. God doesn't always remove the dark valley. But He promises to walk through it with you. That changes everything.

Write Honestly

This is a safe space. No one judges you here.

Is there something really heavy you have been carrying? You can write it here:

Have you told anyone about this? Who could you talk to?

PART 5 — THE PRAYER THAT CALMS YOUR BODY

When You Pray, Your Body Actually Changes

Here is something remarkable: when you pray — especially when you praise God, slow your breathing, and trust that He hears you — something physical happens inside your body. Scientists have studied this and found measurable changes.

Your heart rate slows down

Research shows prayer activates the parasympathetic nervous system — the "rest and restore" system that is the opposite of fight-or-flight.

Your breathing deepens

Slow, intentional prayer naturally slows your breathing. This stimulates the vagus nerve — a long nerve running from your brain to your gut that signals safety to your whole body.

Cortisol levels drop

Studies show that meditation and contemplative prayer lower cortisol — the same stress hormone that makes your stomach hurt and heart pound.

Your brain changes

Prayer focused on praising a loving God has been linked to reduced anxiety symptoms. Those who pray believing God loves and hears them show the greatest benefit.

God designed prayer not just as a spiritual act — but as a physical one. When Philippians 4:7 promises "the peace of God will guard your hearts and minds," that peace has a biology. It calms the amygdala. It lowers cortisol. It activates the vagus nerve. God built the peace into how He built you.

The Prayer Breath — A Step-by-Step Practice

This combines what science knows about slow breathing (vagal nerve activation) with what scripture teaches about prayer. Use this whenever your alarm goes off:

Inhale slowly for 4 counts

"Lord, I come to You..."

Hold gently for 2 counts

"You are bigger than this fear"

Exhale slowly for 6 counts

"I release this worry to You"

Sit quietly for a moment

"Thank You for Your peace"

Repeat 3–5 times

Why the long exhale?

Research from neuroscience shows that a long, slow exhale — longer than the inhale — directly stimulates the vagus nerve. This is the physical pathway that sends a "we are safe" signal from your lungs to your brain. When you breathe out slowly and pray a word of trust, your body hears it as truth. Repeat this 3–5 times and most people notice their heart rate dropping within 90 seconds.

PART 5 CONTINUED — MORE WAYS TO PRAY WHEN ANXIOUS

Kinds of Prayer That Help Anxiety

Praise Prayer

Telling God what is great about Him — His love, His power, His faithfulness. Research shows praise-focused prayer is the most powerfully connected to reduced anxiety. Try: "God, You are bigger than this. You made stars. You can handle this."

Honest Prayer

Just telling God the truth of how you feel. No performance. No perfect words. "God, I am scared. I don't understand. I don't feel okay right now. Help me." The Psalms are full of prayers like this.

Thank-You Prayer

Even in the storm, look for one small thing to thank God for. Scientists call this "gratitude reframing" — it shifts brain activity away from threat mode. "God, thank You that I am not alone."

Scripture Prayer

Pray a Bible verse back to God. "Lord, Your Word says I can cast ALL my anxiety on You because You care for me. I believe You. Here is my fear: ___"

Listening Prayer

After you talk to God, sit quietly for 1–2 minutes. Breathe. Let Him speak. Sometimes He speaks through peace. Sometimes a verse comes to mind. Sometimes just stillness.

> *"Be still, and know that I am God."*
>
> — Psalm 46:10

Try It Now

After trying the prayer breath above, write what you noticed:

What happened in my body during the prayer breath:

What I said to God just now:

DAILY CHECK-IN • DAY 1

How Am I Doing Today?

Date: _____ Time: _____

My Anxiety Level Right Now

Circle or mark where you are on the scale:

1	2	3	4	5
Calm, peaceful	*A little uncomfy*	*Worried, tense*	*Pretty scared*	*Very overwhelmed*

What is going on?

What happened today that made me feel this way?

Where did I feel it in my body?

What did I try?

[ ] Did the prayer breath

[ ] Talked to a trusted grown-up

[ ] Prayed on my own

[ ] Read a scripture verse

[ ] Moved my body (walked, stretched)

[ ] Had a snack and some water

> *"Be strong and courageous. Do not be afraid or terrified, for the Lord your God goes with you."*
>
> — Deuteronomy 31:6

One thing I am grateful for today:

One thing I want to tell God right now:

DAILY CHECK-IN • DAY 2

How Am I Doing Today?

Date: _____ Time: _____

My Anxiety Level Right Now

Circle or mark where you are on the scale:

1	2	3	4	5
Calm, peaceful	*A little uncomfy*	*Worried, tense*	*Pretty scared*	*Very overwhelmed*

What is going on?

What happened today that made me feel this way?

Where did I feel it in my body?

What did I try?

[ ] Did the prayer breath

[ ] Talked to a trusted grown-up

[ ] Prayed on my own

[ ] Read a scripture verse

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DAILY CHECK-IN • DAY 3

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> *"Be strong and courageous. Do not be afraid or terrified, for the Lord your God goes with you."*
>
> — Deuteronomy 31:6

One thing I am grateful for today:

One thing I want to tell God right now:

PRAYER JOURNAL • ENTRY 1

God, right now I feel...

Write a full honest prayer. No editing. Just talk to Him like a friend.

Date: _____

My prayer:

After I prayed, I noticed...

> *"The Lord is close to the brokenhearted and saves those who are crushed in spirit."*
>
> — Psalm 34:18

PRAYER JOURNAL • ENTRY 2

God, I am worried about...

Hand each worry to Him like handing someone something heavy. Name them all.

Date: _____

My prayer:

After I prayed, I noticed...

> *"And the peace of God, which transcends all understanding, will guard your hearts."*
>
> — Philippians 4:7

PRAYER JOURNAL • ENTRY 3

God, thank You for...

Write a full gratitude prayer. Try to fill the whole page.

Date: _____

My prayer:

After I prayed, I noticed...

> *"I sought the Lord, and he answered me; he delivered me from all my fears."*
>
> — Psalm 34:4

PRAYER JOURNAL • ENTRY 4

God, I don't understand why...

You can be confused with God. He can handle your questions.

Date: _____

My prayer:

After I prayed, I noticed...

> *"You are my hiding place; you will protect me from trouble and surround me with songs of deliverance."*
>
> — Psalm 32:7

PRAYER JOURNAL • ENTRY 5

God, I believe You are...

Write who you believe God is. Base it on what you've read or experienced.

Date: _____

My prayer:

After I prayed, I noticed...

> *"Let us then approach God's throne of grace with confidence, so that we may receive mercy and find grace to help us in our time of need."*
>
> — Hebrews 4:16

PART 8 — MY BRAVE MOMENTS

You Are Braver Than You Know

Bravery is not the absence of fear. Bravery is choosing to trust God — and take the next step — even when you are afraid. Every time you used this journal, you were brave. Every time you prayed when you wanted to shut down, you were brave. Every time you told someone how you felt, you were brave.

> *"I can do all this through him who gives me strength."*
>
> — Philippians 4:13

My Brave Moments Journal

Use this page to record moments when you faced a fear, used a coping tool, or trusted God in a hard moment.

1. Date: _____ What happened / what I did:

2. Date: _____ What happened / what I did:

3. Date: _____ What happened / what I did:

4. Date: _____ What happened / what I did:

5. Date: _____ What happened / what I did:

My Personal Promise to Myself

Write a commitment — to yourself and to God — about how you will use what you learned here:

> *"Be strong and courageous. Do not be afraid; do not be discouraged, for the Lord your God will be with you wherever you go."*
>
> — Joshua 1:9

YOU ARE NOT ALONE — RESOURCES & NOTES

If You Need More Help

Talk to Someone

If you are feeling depressed, having thoughts of hurting yourself, or your anxiety is very severe: please tell a trusted adult right away — a parent, a doctor, or another grown-up you trust. You can also call or text 988 (the Suicide & Crisis Lifeline, USA) — available 24/7, free, and confidential.

Recommended for Parents

Consider reaching out to: your pediatrician, a licensed Christian counselor (Psychology Today and Focus on the Family both have therapist finders), your church's pastoral care team, or your child's school counselor.

Research & Sources

This journal was informed by the following peer-reviewed research and authoritative sources:

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8. Prayer and Anxiety (Baylor)

Bradshaw et al. (2014). Anxiety and Amen. Baylor University study on secure attachment to God. https://news.web.baylor.edu

9. Breath-Work & Vagus Nerve

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Scripture translations used: NIV (New International Version) unless otherwise noted.

Disclaimer: This journal is an educational and devotional resource. It is not a substitute for professional mental health treatment. If your child is in crisis, please seek immediate help.

Created with love for every child who has ever felt their heart race and wondered if God noticed. He did. He does. He always will.

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